Making shapes

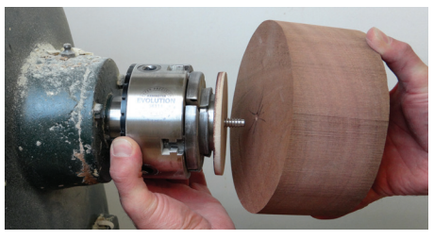
Designs used in faceplate work vary from a simple edge mould to very detailed shapes cut into the face of the wood. For this article, I have made a trophy base and a rosette to show some of the range of cuts required for this type of work. The trophy base involves straight sides and a gentle edge mould which is cut with the wing of the tool whereas the rosette has much deeper beads and coves cut into the face which need careful presentation to keep control of the tool.

Work holding

The term 'faceplate turning' is perhaps a misnomer, or maybe a slightly outdated term. A faceplate can be used, as can a faceplate ring or screw chuck, or indeed any method that you might use to hold a bowl. The thing to consider when choosing your holding method is the end use of the product. In woodturning circles, any unworked surface, or holding marks left in work, are frowned upon and the use of baize was pretty much outlawed in the mid-1990s! That said, in the trophy trade, baize bases are not only encouraged but are a necessity. The trophy bases I make have their bases flattened on the planer and are held on a screw chuck before the baize is applied. Similarly, rosettes are applied to larger pieces of furniture, newel posts or decorative frames and so the backs need no more work than flattening before turning and are, again, held on a screw chuck. However, bases that can be examined closely, especially by woodturners, do need reworking. So techniques employed in bowl turning can be used to remove holding spigots. A recent stool I made as a Christening gift for a friend's son was held with a recess, which was filled with a disc in contrasting timber, engraved with an inscription.

The oak (*Quercus robur*) stool I made recently as a Christening gift

The holding recess beneath the stool seat was filled with a contrasting timber disc with an inscription



Many items can have their bases flattened and be held on a screw chuck with no further need to work them

Trophy base

I make a lot of different trophy bases for a local engraving company. In this case I was asked to make a copy of an original trophy base in sapele (*Entandrophragma cylindricum*). The shape is quite simple, which is ideal for an introduction into faceplate turning. The important areas are the straight section for the silver band, which needs cutting cleanly, cutting straight and to an accurate dimension, and the lower edge mould.

The first stages with any turning are truing up the blank, marking up the positions of the details and removing waste timber by blocking out the final shape of the item. During these roughing and blocking out cuts you have plenty of opportunity to practise your cuts using different presentations and comparing the results before you get to the final shaping and finishing cuts. At this early stage you will be able to tell if the wood is going to behave itself or fight you at every turn. I was fortunate on both of the items I made for the article that the sapele and the American white oak (*Quercus alba*) turned beautifully with no need for extra treatment – which I shall come to later.

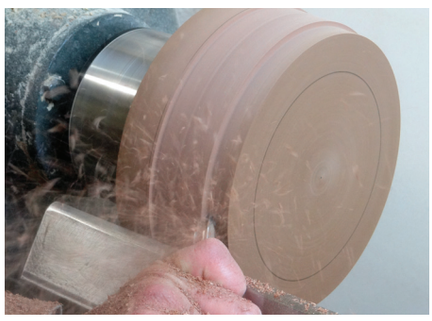
Presentation

The way that you present the tool will have an effect of the outcome of the cut. The more shear the angle of the cut, the cleaner it will be. By shear, what I mean is the angle of presentation. A tool held square to the wood will cut, but will not produce the cleanest surface. By angling the tool to closer to 45° you will find a vast improvement in the cut surface.

You will be using some type of gouge to make these cuts and the exact presentation can make a huge difference to the outcome. Often a less experienced turner will try to cut right on the tip of the tool, but actually, by rotating the tool slightly and cutting just to one side of the tip, it makes the cut more shear and produces a much cleaner surface than when cutting right on the tip. This can be seen in the pictures throughout this article.

You may choose a push cut, slicing the timber with the bevel rubbing, or a shear cut with a razor sharp edge and no bevel contact. Sometimes to find which is best you need to ask the wood by trying each cut to see the results. You will find that shear cuts are great for open shapes and long flowing curves, but for some details cut into the face of the work, you will need to use a bevel rubbing cut. Having the ability to use both types of cut will give you more options and more tools in your turning armoury, to tackle problems that may arise.

The initial roughing of the blank is done with my spindle gouge. Even here you can see the tool is held at a slight angle to the wood, producing a clean cut



During the waste removal stage, you can experiment with different tool presentations to make sure you have it just right for the finishing cut

WT_287_27_31_RICHARD_FINDLEYbdJRmbRFSD.indd 29 06/11/2015 09:27